



Introduction to Art History

OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE · FAMILY COURSE OVERVIEW · GRADES 9–12 · ONE SEMESTER ·
½ CREDIT

~4¼ hrs per week · 50 min/day, M–F

About this overview. This document is an example of how the course might be taught. This page is drawn from the Florida course description rather than a built Optima course, so the specific artworks studied, projects, and activities will be set by the teacher and may vary between the live school and On-Demand. Each teacher also leans into their own strengths and passions; the structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

Introduction to Art History is a one-semester, inquiry-based exploration of works of art across time and cultures. Scholars learn to really look: developing art-specific vocabulary, they explore how the elements of art and principles of design have been used to solve artistic challenges and create meaning, and learn to identify the functions, forms, media, and styles of art tied to particular periods and places. The course includes hands-on art-making alongside the looking, plus a window into careers in art history and criticism — from museums and conservation to curation and writing about art.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

1 Learning to Look (all semester)

Inquiry and observation: describing what is there before judging it, with accurate art vocabulary.

3 Art Across Time (all semester)

Movements, styles, techniques, and materials; major artists, architects, and masterworks and their historical influence.

5 Hands-On Studies (woven through)

Art-making activities that interpret cultural and historical events — this is a looking course with real materials in hand.

2 The Grammar of Art (all semester)

The elements of art and principles of design as the tools artists across history used to solve problems and make meaning.

4 Art Across Cultures (all semester)

Comparing the function and significance of artworks from a variety of cultures, connected to timelines in history and other subjects.

6 Careers and Community (woven through)

Careers in art history and criticism, community resources that preserve and exhibit art, and a digital presentation comparing artists in historical context.

A TYPICAL WEEK

- Sustained looking at real artworks most days, with discussion that describes before it judges.
- Short written analyses using art vocabulary, with research from properly cited sources.
- Periodic hands-on studies connecting the period under study to the scholar's own making.
- A digital presentation project analyzing and comparing artists and artworks in historical context.

TIME COMMITMENT

250 minutes / week

≈ 50 minutes a day, Monday–Friday, for one semester

- Looking, discussion, and short analyses fill most of the scheduled time.
- Research and presentation weeks may run longer.

WHAT SCHOLARS NEED

- A computer with reliable internet and access to Canvas.
- A notebook for art vocabulary, sketches, and analysis notes.
- Basic art supplies for hands-on studies, as assigned.

On-Demand (asynchronous). Scholars move through the course at their own pace, with due dates to keep the year on track. An Optima teacher is available throughout for support, feedback, and grading.

Live school. Live-school scholars take this same course on Optima's VR campus with a teacher and classmates, meeting daily on the school's schedule for one semester.